

KEY DEVELOPMENT

WARRIORS OF PRE-COLUMBIAN AMERICA

The first substantial records of war in Mesoamerica relate to the Maya, who ruled parts of Mexico, Guatemala, and Honduras from around 250CE until the 16th century, when the Spanish conquistadors arrived, ushering in the end of an era.

From 250–900CE, the Mayan lowlands were divided between city-states such as Tikal, Copan, and Yaxchilan, which were in a state of constant war with each other. Mayan warriors fought with spears and sometimes with wooden clubs that were inset with stone or obsidian blades. Records indicate that armour and shields were rarely used by Mayan warriors: their equipment appears to have been more suitable for sporadic raids than large-scale battles. Mayan armies were small and aristocratic, and Tikal's army, the largest, would have numbered no more than 1,000 warriors.

AZTEC TRADITIONS

The Aztecs (Mexico) originated from the Valley of Mexico and eventually settled at their future capital, Tenochtitlán, in 1325, but emerged as an imperial power only in the mid-15th century. They built up a system based on tribute, which ennobled successful warriors and created a society that valued military training, encouraging commoners to join the Aztec army. With a core of trained veterans and a ready supply of fresh warriors, the Aztecs were able to field armies of over 8,000 men and could overwhelm their opponents by sheer force of numbers. In battle, they relied on a barrage of arrows and slingstones, followed by an advance of close-order fighters armed with axes, maces, and clubs. Warriors wore body armour of cotton or leather, and elite soldiers covered these with the skins of fierce animals, such as jaguars.

THE INCA EMPIRE

From 1438, under Pachacutí, the Inca, who had controlled a small state in the Cuzco area of Peru, took over the whole of the central Andes, absorbing other civilizations, such as the Chimú of northern Peru. As well as looting the capital, Chanchan, of its gold and precious stones, the Inca borrowed aspects of Chimú organization to consolidate their rule, handing control of the growing empire's

provinces to a hereditary nobility. A series of well-built roads linked all parts of the empire, and a network of relay stations made it possible to send messages, enabling efficient central control of the provinces. To help rule a vast area that stretched from Ecuador to northern Chile, the Inca built hilltop fortresses and fortified outposts in the border regions of the empire, such as southern Bolivia.

Inca armies' success on the battlefield was not reliant on superior weaponry, but instead on numerical advantage and better use of tactics. Their equipment was equal to, or even less advanced than, that of their rivals; unlike the neighbouring Amazon tribes, they did not even use bows and arrows. Their warriors fought mainly with clubs (initially of stone, then of bronze fitted with stone spikes), slings, and short wooden lances, and they were protected by padded armour. To swell their ranks, they instituted compulsory military service for all men between the ages of 25 and 50, producing a vast pool of recruits; in combat, warriors would employ their long-range weapons (principally the slings) before closing in for hand-to-hand combat. If they suffered a setback in one area, they were able to call on substantial military resources from elsewhere in the empire. Just as the Aztecs fought "flower wars" (see box, right), the Inca seem to



▲ PLACE OF SACRIFICE

The Aztec ruler Axayacatl (1468–81) is seen presiding over a human sacrifice of captives at the Pyramid of Huitzilopochtli, in the Aztec capital Tenochtitlán. The skulls of the victims were placed in racks at the foot of the temple steps.

“And the curs fought back furiously, dealing us wounds and death with their lances and their two-handed swords”

BERNAL DÍAZ DEL CASTILLO, *THE TRUE HISTORY OF THE CONQUEST OF MEXICO*, c.1568



◀ OBSIDIAN SPEAR

Inca warriors usually carried one or two throwing spears made of wood, featuring blades edged with sharp flakes of stone capable of inflicting deep cuts.